

ANI

THE CONGRESS ARSENAL

- Strategic distribution of party tickets, focusing on candidates' winnability
- The domino effect of the Karnataka triumph
- The Six Guarantees promised for welfare and development
- Cashing in on the two-term anti-incumbency of the BRS
- Effort to change the perception of KCR as a formidable rival
- Commitment to citizen-centric governance

candidates more tickets than its rivals.

"The Congress, in the given circumstances, has done a relatively good job in declaring its list of candidates. That it did not walk its talk in providing tickets to BCs is a lack of strategy. But it is also true that there is a dearth of capable BC leaders in the party—a question the Congress has to grapple with," says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches Political Science at NALSAR University, Hyderabad. "That the BC vote is not a single, monolithic bloc—unlike the more consolidated Dalit and Muslim votes—can work to its advantage. A split in the BC vote will be one of the key deciding factors in this election." However, due to protests from multiple aspirants, the party is under pressure to reconsider some candidates before the nomination deadline on November 9. Each case is being considered carefully.

That relates to the other significant shift in the Congress: it is largely following the recommendations of poll strategist Sunil Kanugolu, who played a key role in the Karnataka campaign. The focus is on evaluating the winnability of each contestant, rather than relying on blanket factors like caste. The challenge is to marry this with the imperatives of caste. That's why Kanugolu's teams have been regularly assessing the sentiments of party leaders, cadres and various demographic groups, including castes, women and youth.

As a result, veterans who consider the party ticket their entitlement and wield influence at the local level have found themselves sidelined in favour of potential winners. Additionally, the party has accommodated turncoats from both the BRS and BJP, who hold considerable sway in their respective constituencies and the surrounding regions. Analysts attribute this shift in strategy to the influence of Telangana unit chief A. Revanth Reddy, who sniffs a winning opportunity. Notably, Komatireddy Rajagopal Reddy—an in-